

Table 10: GPT-4 2048 summaries of Janika Oz’s *A History of Burning*.

Strategy	Summary
Hier	“A History of Burning” by Janika Oza follows an Indian family living in Uganda through multiple generations as they navigate hardships, sacrifices, and cultural identity struggles. The story begins with Purbhai, a 13-year-old boy from Gujarat, India, who travels to Africa in search of work during a time of drought and hardship. He eventually marries Sonal, a young girl living with her family in Kenya, and they move to Kampala, Uganda, where they have a son named Vinod. Vinod helps elevate his family’s status in Uganda and marries Rajni, a 19-year-old girl from Karachi, amidst rising tensions between Hindus and Muslims. They raise two daughters, Latika and Mayuri, while facing challenges in their relationship and adapting to their new surroundings. Throughout the story, the characters face hardships, sacrifices, and the struggle to maintain connections to their homeland while navigating the challenges of colonialism, migration, and cultural identity. Years later, Latika grows up and becomes involved in activism against colonial rule in Africa, writing for a secret network called Jicho. She marries Arun, a fellow activist, but struggles with her new life living with his family and the expectations placed upon her. Meanwhile, her sister Mayuri navigates a newly integrated school in Uganda, facing racism and discrimination while considering her future. Eventually, Mayuri studies medicine in India and later returns to her family in the U.S., accompanied by her partner Kunal. The family faces challenges as political changes in Uganda, the Mau Mau rebellion in Kenya, and the lingering effects of British colonialism impact their lives. Latika secretly writes for an anti-government newspaper, JICHO, and her husband Arun is kidnapped due to her involvement. Mayuri is surprised by the changes in her family, particularly her parents’ aging and her younger siblings, Kiya and Hari. She learns that Hari, the son of her deceased sister Latika and her husband Arun, is unaware of his true parentage. As the family members struggle to maintain connections to their homeland and each other, they experience loss, love, and resilience in the face of adversity. Throughout the story, the characters find strength and hope in their shared experiences and love for one another, as they try to build a better life for themselves and their families. The story also explores the challenges faced by immigrants as they adapt to new environments, such as Mayuri’s struggle to practice medicine in Canada and the family’s experiences with racism and violence. In the end, the family must come together to face the destruction of their shop and the loss of their past, finding solace in each other and the hope for a better future. Through their shared experiences and love for one another, they find strength and hope to endure the challenges that come their way. The story highlights the resilience and determination of the characters as they navigate the complexities of life, love, and identity across generations and continents.
Inc	Indian immigrant Purbhai moves his family from Kenya to Uganda, where his son Vinod marries Rajni from Pakistan. They have three daughters, Latika, Mayuri, and Kiya, and face hardships under General Idi Amin’s rule. Forced to leave Uganda, they settle in Toronto, where Vinod and Rajni face cultural challenges. Mayuri marries Kunal but struggles to adapt and returns to her family when her medical degree is unrecognized. Kiya becomes unexpectedly pregnant and faces shame and isolation. The story alternates between Kiya and Mayuri’s perspectives in Toronto and Latika’s life in London. Vinod and Rajni buy a house in Toronto, providing stability for their family. They find a sense of belonging and hope but still worry about their daughters. Latika struggles in London, gaining insight into her past through a chance encounter with a woman from Uganda. Encouraged by her mother-in-law, Latika considers contacting her family. Back in Toronto, Rajni learns that their soap factory in Uganda may be returned to them under a repatriation scheme. She also discovers that Latika visited Uganda, shocking the family with the revelation that she is alive. The family confronts the secrets they’ve kept over the years. Rajni tells her brother Harilal the truth about Latika and their parents’ past as political activists. The family dynamic becomes strained as Harilal reacts with anger and shock. Vinod and Rajni move into an apartment above a friend’s convenience store to give their children space. They find purpose and develop a routine, while Harilal’s attempts to reconnect are met with resistance. Mayuri, now living in her family’s house, tries to maintain normalcy but struggles to connect with Harilal after revealing the truth about Latika. She befriends Darlene, a Trinidadian caretaker who shares her experiences of displacement and finding a new home. Through gardening and connecting with neighbors, they find solace and a sense of community. As the family confronts their past, Kiya tries to hold them together and find forgiveness. They find healing and understanding by sharing stories, exploring themes of family bonds, secrets, and adaptation. Mayuri’s son Hari struggles with the family’s secrets and changes in their relationships. He finds solace in playing basketball with friends who understand his feelings of displacement. Hari’s basketball court is taken away, symbolizing his struggle for belonging and justice. His family tries to reconnect with him, and he begins to understand their silence as a means of survival. Hari learns about a protest against racial injustice and police brutality and decides to participate. The protest becomes chaotic, and Hari is separated from his friends and blinded by tear gas. As the chaos unfolds, Rajni and Vinod search for Hari. The family reunites and witnesses their convenience store burning down, but they resolve to rebuild and support one another. They come to terms with their past and find strength in their shared experiences, such as gardening and connecting with their community. In the epilogue, Latika and her husband reflect on their lives and the stories they’ve shared. They find solace in their connection and the knowledge that what the water takes, it returns. The family’s journey is marked by resilience, forgiveness, and the power of community to heal and rebuild. The novel also explores the importance of knowing one’s history and family lineage to achieve a greater understanding of personal identity. Each family member faces moments where they must decide between complicity and resistance, and their family legacy influences their decisions. The novel emphasizes the power of storytelling and the interconnectedness of the characters as they navigate their relationships, secrets, and the challenges they face. Food plays a significant role in the narrative, symbolizing community, belonging, and the characters’ connection to their cultural roots. At the heart of the novel is the idea of community and collectivism, as well as the question of who is included and excluded in these spaces. The author hopes readers will reflect on these themes and the possibilities of solidarity, as the characters’ fates are entangled and they rely on one another.

Table 11: GPT-3.5-Turbo 2048 summaries of Janika Oz’s *A History of Burning*.

Strategy	Summary
Hier	“A History of Burning” by Janika Oza is a multi-generational story that follows the lives of Purbhai, Sonal, and their children Vinod, Rajni, Mayuri, Kiya, Meetu, and Hari through displacement, cultural struggles, and personal tragedies. The novel is set during political unrest in Kenya and Uganda in the mid-twentieth century, where the family faces poverty and exploitation as migrant workers. Purbhai leaves his family in India to work in Kenya, where he faces poverty and exploitation as a migrant worker. He is haunted by the guilt of leaving his family behind and is forced to make difficult choices, including burning down a cluster of abandoned huts. Purbhai marries Sonal, and they start a family, facing financial struggles and the impact of colonialism. The story explores themes of poverty, desperation, and the harsh realities of migrant workers. The family faces political unrest and racial tensions in Uganda during the time of the country’s independence from British rule. They are forced to leave Uganda due to the political instability caused by Idi Amin’s regime. The story also delves into Mayuri’s struggles as a medical professional facing discrimination in Toronto. The characters are motivated by their desire to protect their families and survive in a dangerous environment, with themes of family, resilience, and the challenges faced by immigrants in adapting to new cultures. The story follows their children, Vinod and Rajni, and their struggles with identity, cultural expectations, and displacement. The family’s relationships and dynamics are explored, and their motivations and fears are hinted at. The family lives in Uganda during the time of the country’s independence from British rule, and the story explores themes of grief, family, and tradition. Purbhai and Sonal celebrate the birth of their third granddaughter, Kiya, and plan a picnic at the Botanical Gardens in Entebbe. The family faces political unrest and racial tensions, with Purbhai’s granddaughter Latika becoming involved in a resistance movement against tyranny. The story features non-linear narratives and flashbacks, with Purbhai reflecting on his past and the consequences of his actions. The novel shifts between different characters’ experiences, flashbacks, and tragedies, providing a rich and layered narrative. Specifically, the characters’ past traumas, including the disappearance of Latika, add complexity to their struggles and sense of loss, while moments of triumph and fear reveal the human capacity for resilience and transformation. Beyond the family’s personal struggles, the novel delves into themes such as community inclusivity, belonging, and solidarity. Despite the family’s struggles, the story presents moments of hope and triumph, such as Vinod’s dream of buying a house, and moments of uncertainty and fear, such as Hari’s fall from a ladder. Ultimately, the story presents a nuanced and emotionally resonant portrait of immigrant life and the human capacity for resilience and transformation. The characters experience moments of hope and triumph, such as Vinod’s dream of buying a house, and moments of uncertainty and fear, such as Hari’s fall from a ladder. The setting is in Uganda, Kenya, and Canada, and the story highlights the importance of family, resilience, and the challenges faced by immigrants in adapting to new cultures. The characters are motivated by their desire to protect their families and survive in a dangerous environment. The story presents a consistent and chronological narrative, despite featuring non-linear narratives, flashbacks, and switches between alternate worlds or viewpoints. In conclusion, “A History of Burning” is a complex and emotionally resonant story that explores themes of family, resilience, displacement, and the challenges faced by immigrants in adapting to new cultures. The story follows the lives of Purbhai, Sonal, and their children through political unrest, racial tensions, and personal tragedies. Despite the family’s struggles, the story presents moments of hope and triumph, ultimately presenting a nuanced and layered portrait of immigrant life and the human capacity for resilience and transformation.
Inc	A History of Burning follows the lives of nine family members over a century, exploring the importance of knowing one’s history and family lineage to achieve a greater understanding of personal identity. The novel emphasizes the significance of community and belonging, while also considering who is included and excluded in these spaces. Food plays a pivotal role in placemaking and finding one’s way into new understandings of home and belonging. The protagonist of the novel is the family itself, and the choice of whose voice to enter for specific moments was often intuitive. Vinod’s health is declining, and he suffers a stroke. His family worries about him, and Rajni struggles with memories of the past, including the secret of her lost daughter, Latika. Mayuri and Kiya tell Hari and Meetu about their lost sister, and they all eat cake together. Hari confides in Sol about his boss accusing him of stealing tips, and they start playing basketball together. While Hari marches in a protest with Solomon, Marcus, and Sami, the protest becomes violent, and Hari is blinded by a searing fog. He stumbles on, trying to feel his way unseeing over whose streets. Hari yells out the names of his family, who have come and gone, and sees visions of a body huddled in a dank chamber, a tree blooming red as flame, and a boat dimly bobbing across black waters. The chemical fog hangs like a white sheet in the night sky, and Hari opens his eyes to see the destruction around him. He runs home, and his family is relieved to see him. Later, Vinod and Rajni meet with a woman on a rocky outcropping off the shore. They recognize each other and speak of people remote and unknowable as the land before the water. The woman has traveled far, and yet in all the movement, a part of her feels restored. Encircled by her family, she knows that she has come not just forward, but also back. When their conversation falters, they take in the stillness around them, how the waves make silence with sound. They let the tide crest over their feet and remember what the water has carried and what it has swallowed. The man slips a little on a rock slick with algae, and the woman rights him in a gesture unpracticed and natural. They recall losses that they cannot know. Beyond them, the tide continues. The water shifts the sand, reassembles the shells, sucks the stones to pebbles. The waves break and mend, break and mend.

Table 12: Claude 2048 summaries of Janika Oz’s *A History of Burning*.

Strategy	Summary
Hier	The novel follows an Indian family across multiple generations, beginning in late 19th century India when the patriarch Purbhai boards a ship to Africa seeking work. Tricked into indentured labor in Africa, Purbhai endures difficult conditions building the Uganda Railway. Years later in 1902, his granddaughter Sonal notices the strong arms of an Indian laborer, Purbhai, who comes asking for work at her father’s shop in Nairobi. Sonal develops an interest in Purbhai, who remains quiet about his traumatic past. The story shifts to 1917, where Sonal is now a married woman with two daughters, living in Kampala, Uganda. Her husband Purbhai insists on sending money to his aging mother in India, while Sonal resents having another child amidst financial struggles. In the 1940s, their daughter-in-law Rajni secretly poisons her husband Vinod to make him too ill for military conscription during World War II, afraid he will die in combat. Years later, another descendant, Latika marries a local activist named Arun, against her parents’ wishes. During political turmoil in the 1960s, Arun is imprisoned for sedition. Latika flees Uganda for London, abandoning their infant son. Decades later, Latika’s sister Mayuri arranges her son Hari’s marriage to a woman named Rajni, keeping secret that Rajni is actually Latika’s daughter-in-law. In the 1970s, President Idi Amin expels Asians from Uganda, forcing the family to scatter across continents. They lose their home, bonds, and history in the upheaval. In 1980s Canada, Rajni and Vinod struggle to assimilate while hiding the truth about Hari’s parentage. Hari feels disconnected from his family’s silenced history. He grapples with fighting racism alongside friends versus fulfilling his duties to their shop and ill grandfather. When Hari finally learns about his mother Latika, he is furious over the lies. The family ruptures further when Latika mysteriously returns after 30 years, devastating Rajni. They continue navigating the legacy of Latika’s unexplained absence and the cultural erasure caused by their exile from Uganda. But glimmers of reconciliation emerge, as when Rajni and Vinod open a new shop providing community. Later, while caring for their bedridden grandfather, Hari realizes his family’s perseverance outweighs the hidden past. Ultimately, Latika’s return signifies the possibility of mending fissures left by displacement and secrecy. Spanning a tumultuous century, the epic novel conveys a family’s resilience and quest for home and belonging amidst upheaval.
Inc	Rajni cared for her ailing husband Vinod after his stroke. Their adopted son Hari moved back in to help, though Rajni still felt distant from him after revealing his birth mother Latika was alive. Rajni heard warnings about potential violence at an upcoming protest rally, but let Hari decide to attend and support his marginalized community. Rajni reflected on her family’s complex history and relationships. She considered her daughters Kiya and Mayuri, who had tried in their own ways to heal family rifts. Rajni realized she had once been close with Hari and longed for that again. She thought of the connections between her family’s struggles and those of other marginalized groups like Hari’s friends. Rajni gained perspective on the importance of open communication to bring people together across divides. Meanwhile, Vinod slowly recovered, regaining mobility and strength. He woke up determined to become more independent. Vinod and Rajni both acknowledged their growing frailty, but continued supporting each other. Vinod’s daughters Kiya and Mayuri tended a community garden, bringing together neighbors and friends. Though facing opposition, Kiya was inspired by her ancestor’s vision of a shared place welcoming to all. She hoped the garden could be part of creating an inclusive home. Latika had told them the story of how their grandfather Vinay ripped up homes and displaced communities when building the Ugandan railway. Vinod now reflected on his father’s complex legacy and motivations. Despite their troubled relationship, he empathized with Vinay’s desire for security and belonging. Vinod realized he himself had fought hard to establish a home in Canada, sometimes neglecting to appreciate what he had. Now physically weakened but gaining perspective, Vinod hoped to find contentment. Hari went to the protest rally downtown with his friend Solomon and others. As the peaceful protest ended, tensions rose between protesters and police. Chaos broke out, with violence erupting on both sides. Police barricaded the protesters, using tear gas and force to disperse them. In the confusion, Hari lost sight of Solomon and the others. Blinded by the tear gas, Hari desperately tried to find his way and reconnect with his friends during the fray. Rajni and Vinod went searching for Hari during the chaotic protest. In their confusion amidst the clashes, they struggled to find their way home. Fortunately their daughter Meetu arrived and helped guide them back, reuniting with the rest of the family. They returned home to find their shop had been destroyed in a fire during the fray. Though devastated, the family drew strength from one another, committed to rebuilding together.